



PAKISTANI PRO-TALIBAN MILITANTS STAND GUARD ON A STREET IN MINGORA

allowed bazaars to reopen for the first time in months and many were celebrating the absence of the sounds of staccato gunfire and thuds of tank shells. But even before the caravan arrived, questions were being raised about the durability of the 'peace' achieved in the form of surrender.

The lush green forests of Swat Valley and the icy blue waters of Gilgit river that snake through the area in north-western Pakistan were once a magnet for tourists. Despite massive deforestation over the last three

decades and its generally poor and conservative population, Swat retained the image of an idyllic paradise in the minds of most Pakistanis. That image was decisively shaken three years ago when reports began to come in of rising militancy in the region led by a radical pseudo-cleric who rode a white steed and ran his own illegal FM radio channel that exhorted jihad against 'the infidels'. Fazlullah, a one-time ski-lift operator at Malam Jabba, near Mignora, was dubbed 'Mullah Radio' by locals. The image was further shat-



tered when the army launched an operation to rid the region of militants, many of whom they said had infiltrated the area from neighbouring Bajaur tribal agency and even Afghanistan.

But the seriousness of the issue was only driven home last year, when a tentative peace agreement between the provincial government and militants collapsed, and large parts of the Swat Valley became no-go areas even as the militants resorted to even more brutal methods to enforce their writ. Hundreds of schools were blown up by the militants opposed to girls' education, men were whipped for shaving their beards, video and music shops were either bombed or forced to close down, and women were forbidden from venturing out without an accompanying male relative. The main centre of Mingora town, known as Grain Chowk, quickly became known locally as 'Khooni Chowk', as militants regularly dumped beheaded bodies of 'spies' or 'government collaborators' there every morning. Thousands of people, caught between the brutality of the militants and the oftentimes indiscriminate reaction of the army, fled the area.

Now, the extent of what has been termed as 'Talibanisation' of the area has been laid bare by the agreement announced on February 16 between the provincial government—led by a secular coalition of the Awami National Party (ANP) and the Pakistan People's Party (PPP)—and a banned organisation